

Municipal administrative capacity and secondary school accessibility in Brazil

The paper proposal poses a clear and interesting research question whose relevance is readily apparent: whether municipal administrative capacity translates into more accessible secondary schooling in Brazil has broad implications for public administration, urban planning and, of course, education and development. The design is clean, the causal intuition is plausible, and the choice of Brazilian municipalities offers sufficient within-country variation to make the empirical exercise meaningful. The combination of georeferenced data with fiscal and administrative indicators is a genuine strength, and the explicit awareness of spatial clustering signals methodological care from the outset. That said, I would ask for clarification on a few points:

First, on the operationalization of “administrative capacity”. The proposal currently measures it through a myriad of fiscal indicators, which arguably capture fiscal capacity rather than administrative capacity in the broader sense (managerial quality, personnel qualifications, procurement efficiency, etc.). It would strengthen the construct validity of the study to complement the fiscal variables with at least one indicator of bureaucratic quality. Without this, there is a risk that H1 is effectively testing “richer municipalities have closer schools”, which is closer to the confounder than to the hypothesis.

Second, on the causal interpretation. The proposal acknowledges confounding from wealth and population density and plans robustness checks via alternative OLS specifications. This is a reasonable starting point, but OLS with controls will likely not be enough to sustain a causal reading. I would encourage considering [1.] municipality fixed effects if a panel dimension is feasible, [2.] an instrumental variable strategy, or [3.] at minimum, a clear framing of the contribution as *associational* rather than *causal*, to avoid overclaiming.

Third, on the outcome variable. “Average distance from settlement centroid to the nearest secondary school” is a sensible proxy, but it is silent on school quality and effective accessibility (transport infrastructure, terrain, river networks, etc.). A brief discussion of why physical distance is the most policy-relevant outcome, or –ideally– a supplementary analysis using travel time where feasible, would pre-empt an obvious reviewer objection and truly strengthen the overall analysis.

Overall, this is a well-scoped and empirically feasible project with a clear policy payoff. Tightening the conceptualization of the key independent variable and being explicit about the causal claims would just (hopefully) raise its contribution. Congratulations!